

Double whammy: Manu Bhaker won her second bronze medal of the Paris Olympics as she combined with Sarabjot Singh to win bronze in the 10m air pistol mixed team event.

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for the match, we saw that she had won the bronze again. So, we were like, 'It's our time; nobody can stop us'. Really (feeling) positive," said Satwik Rankireddy, a medal favourite alongside Chirag Shetty in badminton men's doubles.

Manu's humour helps in breaking down the stress of the Games. After winning a second medal in the mixed team event, she told *Sportstar* how she once created a fake social media profile to defend two-time Olympic medallist Sindhu from trolls. Sindhu, pursuing her place in history and a third Olympic medal, laughed at the youngster's unstinted support while wishing Manu the best for a third medal of her own.

The records will show just how many medals she won in such a short time, but only Manu will know how hard it was to get to this point. "It might have looked easy, but it's not. It was very hard. There were a lot of lessons I had to learn. Not all of them were easy. But they all had a role to play in what I am today," she says.

She is just 22, but there's a lifetime of wisdom packed in her. Her story is not just of a prodigy — she had won World Cup and Commonwealth Games gold by the time she was 16 — but of redemption. After a reality check with the harshest of bruising at the Tokyo Olympics, the teenager was put under the kind of stress that few people ever experience and fewer survive. For a lesser person, the story would have ended there.

It took immense strength of character to find her way back into the sport. Nothing will exemplify that personal growth more than how Manu learned to work once again with her coach, Jaspal Rana. It's a decision he says he never would have made if he were in her



shoes. It's also a decision that, even she says, has been instrumental in her performance at Chateauroux.

Calming influence

There was a moment early in the final of the women's 10m air pistol event at the Olympic Games when Manu turned away from the target in front of her towards the spectator gallery.

She knew exactly where to look.

When she entered the finals hall a few minutes earlier, Manu had scanned the faces in the crowd sitting in the bleachers behind her.

She had looked past the sea of spectators, with a smattering of hopeful Indian faces, and zeroed in on a man in dark glasses with a notebook in his hands. It was her coach, Jaspal. She would remember his position on the extreme left-hand side of the viewing gallery.

After shooting two consecutive scores of 9.6 in her eighth and ninth shots of the final, Manu had slipped from the medal bracket to fourth place behind Asian Championship bronze medallist Thu Vinh Trinh of Vietnam. She needed reassurance.